🐖 Livestock Judging: Reading

Ag Science 1 · Unit 7 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Livestock Judging PowerPoint (Blank Out notes) + Livestock Judging Score Card

Name: _____

How to Judge Livestock

Livestock judging is an FFA Career Development Event. A class is four animals of the same kind. The judge places them first to fourth and explains the placing with reasons.

Judges look at four big traits. Muscle is thickness in the leg, loin and ham; more muscle means more meat. Structure is feet, legs and bone; legs should be strong, straight and set square and wide. Balance means the animal is level, long and smooth. Condition is the amount of fat cover; too much fat is called over-conditioned.

Breeding animals are kept to have young, like a ewe, heifer or gilt. Judges look for a feminine head and neck, a level top, a long body and sound feet and legs. A gilt should also have an even, well-spaced underline (teats).

Market animals are raised for meat, like a lamb, steer, goat or barrow. Judges look for the most muscle, a trim middle and the right amount of fat. An ideal market barrow has a long, thick, muscular ham, a level top and legs set wide apart. An over-conditioned, light-muscled barrow has too much fat over the shoulder and a flat, narrow ham.

Key words: a heifer is a young female cow that has not had a calf; a steer is a castrated male beef animal; a gilt is a young female pig kept for breeding; a barrow is a castrated male pig raised for meat.

Check your reading

1. What are the four big traits judges look at?

2. How is judging a breeding animal different from a market animal?

3. What is a barrow?